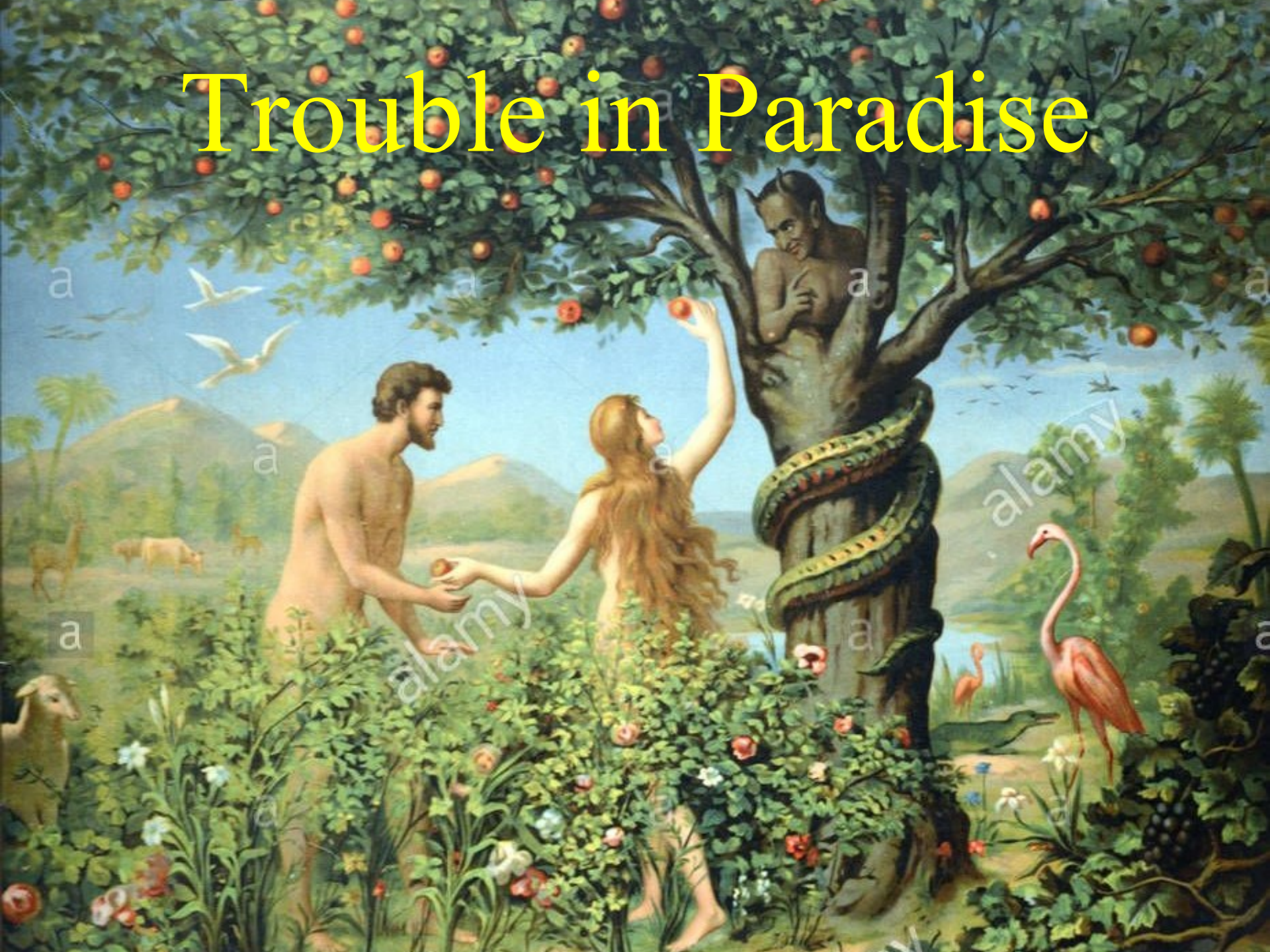
Trouble in Paradise



Review

Key Points to Remember

- Since grains and shrubs are not growing in the field because there is no water or man, God waters the ground with a mist and creates a man.
- Surprisingly, God places the man at rest in the utopia of paradise, rather than at work tilling the ground
- In spite of his wonderful situation, the man needs a helper.
- The man rejects the first helpers presented to him but then finds a perfect mate in the one God created from his own rib.
- The man and the woman are in perfect unity and in complete comfort and security in a place of God's blessing and provision.

The Serpent

Animal or Satan?

- Explicitly called an animal
- Sin in the world?
  - Romans: sin entered the world through the sin of humanity

    Therefore, just as through one man sin entered the world and through sin, death, thus also death has come upon all men, since all have sinned.
  - Genesis 3: evil is present pre-Fall
- Later Scripture
  - Rev 12:19

    So the great dragon, the ancient serpent, the one called "Devil" and "the Satan," the one who deceives the whole world, was cast down to the earth."
  - Satan as the father of lies *(John 8:44)*
  - Serpents represent evil: (*Deut 32:22; Pss 58:4; 91:13; 140:4; Isa 14:29; Jer 8:17*)
- Conclusion: an animal, but representing Satan in some way!

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And he said to the woman . . .

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Who are the "animals of the field"?

"The Lord God formed from the ground all ***the animals of the field****, and all the birds of the heavens. And he brought them to the man to see what he would call them."* *(Gen 2:19)*

Now the serpent was more clever than ***all the rejected animals****, which the Lord God had made.*

And he said to the woman . . .

And he said to the woman:

"Did God really say,

'You all may not eat from every tree of the garden'?"

And the woman said to the serpent:

"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden God said,

'You all may not eat from it and you all may not touch it, lest you all die'"

And the serpent said to the woman:

"You all will not surely die. For God knows that, in the day that you all eat from it, your eyes will be open, and you all will be like God, knowing good and bad."

And he said to the woman:

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'You all may not eat from every tree of the garden'?"

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Serpent-Woman Dialogue

- The serpent raises doubt with respect to God
  - "*Did God really say. . . ?*"
  - Changes wording, changing emphases
    - Serpent: "*You all shall not eat from every tree*" vs.
    - God: "*From every tree you may freely eat*"

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      - Removes pre-posed (emphatic) "from every"
      - Omits "freely"
  - "*God knows*"
    - Implies that God is holding something back
  - "*You will not certainly die*"
    - Directly contradicts God's statement of the consequences
    - Refers to what God said as "speaking" rather than "commanding"

And the woman said to the serpent:

"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden God said,

'You all may not eat from it and you all may not touch it, lest you all die'"

And the woman said to the serpent:

"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden God said,

'You all may not eat from it and you all may ***not touch it****, lest you all die'"*

Serpent-Woman Dialogue

The Woman's Response

- "*Not touch it*"
  - Portrays God as more restrictive than he is

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"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden God said,

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God:

"From every tree of the garden you may ***freely*** *eat."*

Serpent-Woman Dialogue

The Woman's Response

- "*Nor touch it*"
  - Betrays a negative perception of God as restrictive
- "*You may eat of the trees*"
  - Omits "freely," underplaying the bountiful nature of God's blessing
  - Omits "every," de-emphasizing the bountiful nature of God's blessing

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"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is in the middle of the garden God said,

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God:

*"From **every** tree of the garden you may **freely** eat."*

And the woman said to the serpent:

"From the fruit of the trees of the garden we may eat. But, from the fruit of the tree that is ***in the middle of the garden*** *God said,*

'You all may not eat from it and you all may not touch it, lest you all die'"

Serpent-Woman Dialogue

The Woman's Response

- "*Nor touch it*"
  - Betrays a negative perception of God as restrictive
- "*You all may eat of the trees*"
  - Omits "freely," underplaying the bountiful nature of God's blessing
  - Omits "all," de-emphasizing the bountiful nature of God's blessing
- Places the bad tree in the ***middle*** of the garden, a place not given it by the narrator.

And the serpent said to the woman:

"You all will not surely die. For God knows that, in the day that you all eat from it, your eyes will be open, and you all will be like God, knowing good and bad."

- The woman says . . . "*lest you all die*"
- The serpent responds . . . "*You all will not* ***surely*** *die.*"
- Then the serpent changes the topic to a selfish God
- Note:
  - The serpent is not lying outright
  - He is deceiving.
  - God had to banish them from the tree of life, lest they live forever

And the woman saw that the tree was good to eat,

and that it was pleasant to the eyes

and the tree was desired to make wise

And she took its fruit.

And she ate.

And she gave to the man with her.

And he ate.

And the woman saw that the tree was ***good to eat****,*

and that it was ***pleasant to the eyes***

and the tree was ***desired to make wise***

And she took its fruit.

And she ate.

And she gave to the man with her.

And he ate.

- First two assessments reflect the description in Chapter 2
- The third assessment comes from the serpent

Reflections on the Conversation

- The topic is the knowledge of good and bad
  (the focus of the entire account)
- Incites an ***independent*** assessment
- Serpent's Strategy
  - separates the woman
  - entices her to make an independent assessment
    - about God's bountiful provision
    - about God's motives
  - leads her to an incorrect assessment

The Storyline

- God created humanity to represent him and rule the animals
- Ruling requires making assessments and decisions
- Good decisions will be consistent with God's will . . .
- And God prohibits independence *(don't eat)*
- God leads humanity in making decisions *(naming animals)*
- Now humanity makes assessments apart from God's guidance
- Result
  - ruined creation
  - ruined image of God *(unity in plurality)*
  - loss of communion between God and humanity

Man – Woman Relationship

- God's design
  - the man created to serve God
  - the man needed help
  - the woman created to help the man serve God
- In the fall . . .
  - The serpent approaches the woman alone
  - He incites her to make an assessment for both her and the man
  - The woman is deceived and makes a bad decision
  - The man disobeys God and obeys the woman
  - Neither one fulfilled their created purpose

And their eyes were opened.

And they knew that they were naked.

And they sewed together fig leaves.

And they made loincloths for themselves.

And they heard the voice of the Lord God

walking in the garden in the cool of the day.

And he hid, the man and his wife,

from the presence of the Lord God

in the midst of the trees of the garden

Resultant Action

- The serpent was correct: their eyes were opened
- ***But***, they were deceived regarding the consequences
- They saw themselves as naked
- They covered themselves
- They hid from God

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- They saw themselves as **naked**
- They **covered themselves**
- They **hid from God**

Naked

- Independent of God they become self-aware
- They make ***another*** independent assessment
  - nakedness is detrimental
    - God created them naked, so he considered it beneficial
    - 1 John 1 *(walk in the light)*
      - *God is not concerned with our nakedness ("come to the light")*
        - *Ps 103:14 – "He knows our form, he remembers that we are dust"*
      - *The problem is with us . . . we are ashamed and hide from the light*
      - *The solution is knowing that our sin is "covered"*
  - they are vulnerable and ashamed
    - but to what and to whom?
    - to whom else but each other?
- Consequences
  - image of God is lost *(complete oneness)*
  - proper function is lost *(they can't trust each other)*
  - continuation of God's work is lost *(now must serve self)*

Coverings

- They made themselves coverings . . .

  but still perceived themselves as naked and exposed.
- A covering of tree leaves??
  - Covering themselves from what should be their spiritual food
- A covering of their loins??
  - region of sexual organs
  - male and female of Genesis 1
  - ultimate union of both to create life
  - now covered (hidden) from each other

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"God's voice in the cool of the ***day***"?

- Hebrew: "Hear a voice" implies a degree of intimacy
- Hebrew: "concerning," "regarding," "according to," but never "in"
- Hebrew: "wind/spirit" not "cool"
- "Day" > another word for "light" *(Genesis 1)*
- Literal translation . . .

  "to/concerning/according to Spirit/spirit/wind the day/light"
- Suggested literal translation . . .

  "according to the Spirit of the light"
- Dynamic equivalent translation . . .

  "And they heard the voice of the Lord God, the Spirit of light, walking about in the garden."
- Significance:
  - They hid from an intimate interaction with the one who reveals all things.

Summary

- In spite of God's placing them in paradise . . .
- Humanity decides that God can't be trusted
- They seize for themselves the right/responsibility to decide for themselves what is in their best interest
- They become self-aware and self-protective
- They pull back and from each other
- They hide from intimacy with God

<u>Note:</u>

- These are natural consequences.
- There will also be divine judgment.